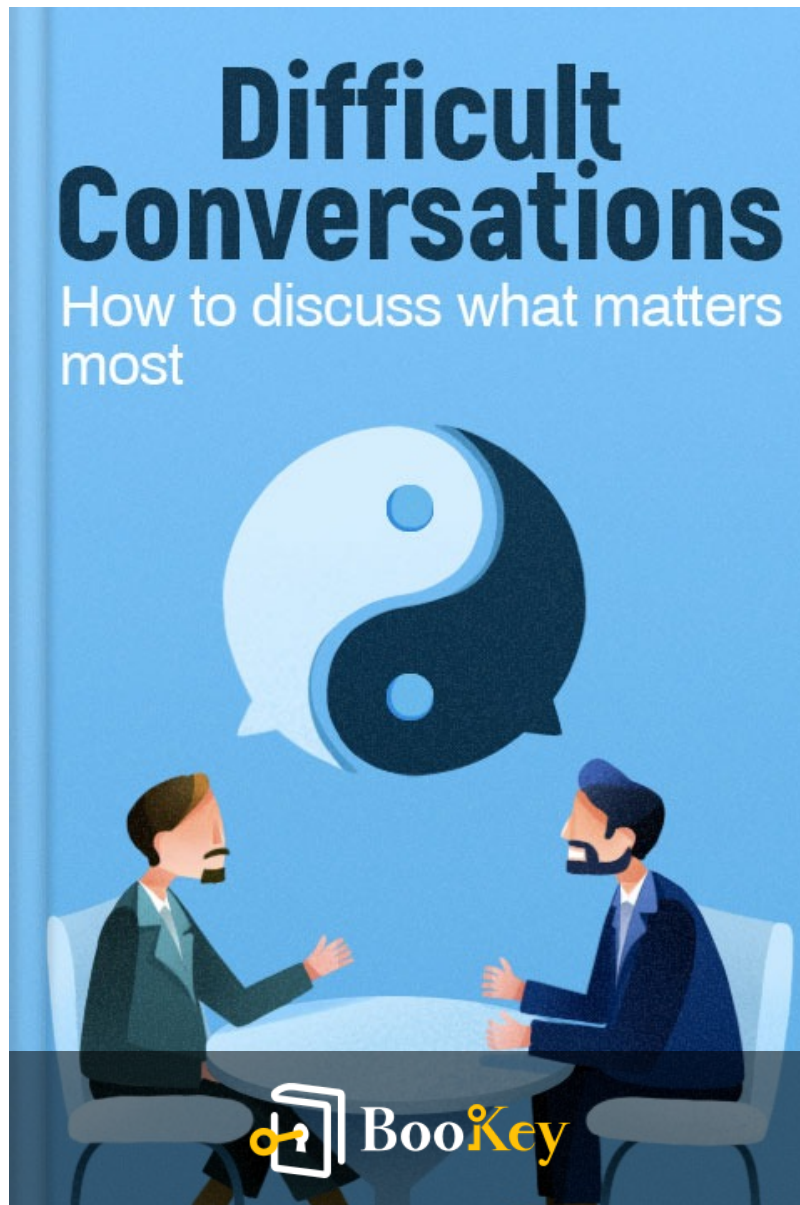


Difficult Conversations PDF

Douglas Stone, Bruce Patton, Sheila Heen



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Difficult Conversations

How to discuss what matters most

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About the book

From time to time in our daily lives, we get into difficult conversations, such as when we ask for a promotion or end a relationship. Such conversations, though seemingly ordinary, leave us feeling anxious and put us in a dilemma. So, what should we do in difficult conversations? This book 'Difficult Conversations: How to Discuss What Matters Most' can give you the answer. This book is the product of fifteen years of research by the Harvard Negotiation Project and has been an international bestseller since its publication.

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About the author

This book was co-authored by three renowned American communication experts, Douglas Stone, Bruce Patton, and Sheila Heen. Douglas Stone is a well-known communication expert in the U.S. He has provided consulting services to many top tier organizations, including Boeing, Accenture, IBM, and JPMorgan. Bruce Patton is co-author of the bestseller 'Getting to Yes: Negotiating Agreement Without Giving In'. Sheila Heen is a Lecturer on Law at Harvard Law School. She also coaches lawyers and executives in big companies on relevant subjects.

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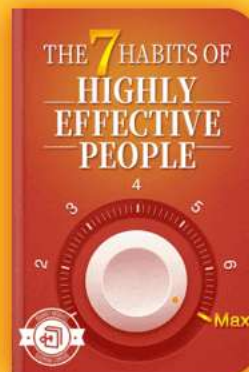
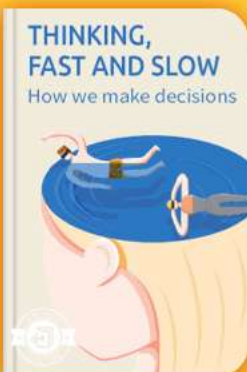


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Summary Content List

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Chapter 2 : Why difficult conversations happen?

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Chapter 1 : Overview

Hi, welcome to Bookey. Today we will unlock the book ‘Difficult Conversations: How to Discuss What Matters Most’. Upon hearing its title, you may wonder, don’t difficult conversations occur only in diplomatic, political, or business negotiations? Well, in fact, difficult conversations are part of each and everyone's life. At work or at home, we may run into difficult conversations. They can happen when our promotion request is turned down, or when a picky employee refuses to do their job. They can happen when we want to end a relationship but feel guilty about it, or when we try to convince our kids to study but they don't listen. Difficult conversations even take place when we fail to solve trivial problems with our neighbors. Such conversations, though seemingly common, bring us anxiety and put us in a dilemma. We don't want to hurt others, while we also want to be treated fairly. So what makes our conversations so difficult? And how should we deal with them? The book ‘Difficult Conversations’ offers us great solutions.

This book is the product of fifteen years of research by the Harvard Negotiation Project. Sometimes referred to as the “Harvard Method,” the book aims to solve our

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communication problems by teaching us essential ways of thinking, the right stances to take toward our feelings, and skills to communicate effectively. These guidelines can help us solve various communication problems so that we can manage our relationships well in different situations.

Whether they are personal or involving business and diplomatic negotiations, we will always be able to handle the conversations with great ease using the tools offered in this book.

The book has been an international bestseller since its publication. Readers from all walks of life have responded positively to it. It has helped parents who have a hard time ensuring their children's education find the right way to educate them. It has also helped company leaders solve internal conflicts and keep their teams united. The book is used as a teaching material at many law schools, business schools, and other colleges.

The authors of the book summarize three components of difficult conversations and the corresponding strategies to deal with them. They also give us problem-solving suggestions to help us shift our conversation from a “message delivery stance” to a “learning stance.”



Subsequently, the authors then give us detailed steps on how to tackle a difficult conversation. They teach readers the skills and tactics on how to start a conversation, ask the right questions, and bring a conversation back on track when it reaches a deadlock.

This book was co-authored by three renowned American communication experts, Douglas Stone, Bruce Patton, and Sheila Heen. Douglas Stone is a well-known communication expert in the U.S. He has provided consulting services to many top tier organizations, including Boeing, Accenture, IBM, JP Morgan. Bruce Patton is co-author of the bestseller 'Getting to Yes: Negotiating Agreement Without Giving In'. Sheila Heen is a Lecturer on Law at Harvard Law School. She also coaches lawyers and executives in big companies on relevant subjects.

This bookey will unlock the book for you in two parts.

Part One: Why difficult conversations happen.

Part Two: How to correctly handle difficult conversations.

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Chapter 2 : Why difficult conversations happen?

A difficult conversation occurs anytime you find it hard to talk about something. After studying hundreds of conversations of various types, the authors found that no matter what the subject was, our conversations always shared the same underlying structure. To put it simply, no matter what the subject, our thoughts and feelings fall into three categories, or “conversations.” They are: the “What Happened?” Conversation, the Feelings Conversation, and the Identity Conversation. People make predictable mistakes when having one of these Three Conversations. We get stuck in arguments, carry negative emotions, and blindly try to protect our self-esteem. Any difficult conversation cannot avoid the Three Conversations, and they are exactly the reason why our conversations become difficult. Let’s talk about them one by one.

First of all, let’s look at the “What Happened?” Conversation. In a “What Happened?” Conversation, we make assumptions, which causes meaningless and endless disputes. When something unpleasant happens, the focus of



the conversation revolves around who is right, who is wrong, who said what, who should take responsibility, and so on. We turn to argue about almost every detail. Why is that? It's because we tend to make three assumptions and believe in each of their righteousness. And that makes our conversations fall into a continuous loop of arguments.

The first assumption we hold is that it's always the other person's fault. This is the "I am right, you are wrong" mindset. We care too much about being right or wrong, as such, both sides of the conversation turn to argue vigorously with one another in order to prove they are right. Consequently, we fail to focus on finding the reason behind the problem and its corresponding solution, and our conversation moves to a dead end.

The second assumption is about intentions. When we don't agree with each other, we assume that the other side is ill-intentioned. If the other person yells at us, we believe he or she is deliberately trying to hurt our feelings. Sometimes we even take others' concern as actually their intention to control us. For instance, when you try to persuade your parents against buying bad stocks from sales calls, they may in turn believe you are trying to take control of their money.



We often hear people say that their goodwill is sometimes regarded as malice, which is when their intentions are being mistaken.

The third one is that we assume others are to be blamed for the problem. Consider this example; If a company loses one of its major clients, every employee would assume that someone else is responsible for the loss. Internal turmoil will arise as everyone tries to evade responsibility. No one would admit that he or she did anything wrong. Everyone would simply project an "it's not my fault" allure. People blame one another like players passing the 'buck' during poker games; all trying to get rid of trouble as soon as possible. Everyone tries hard to stay clear from taking responsibility, and consequently, conflicts build up among employees.

The three assumptions mentioned above are together what cause difficult conversations to arise in the first place. To turn the situation around so we can achieve the goal of our conversation, we need to adjust our way of thinking and shift to a learning conversation.

Concerning the first assumption, in which the other person is always wrong, we need to stop arguing about who is right



and who is wrong. During such an argument, each side takes a stance and argues only in favor of their own points. As a result, it's easy to slip into aimless disputes and only emphasize on who wins in the end, with no consideration of the other person's points. However, there is always no absolute right or wrong; it is just a question of perspectives. We all grow up from different backgrounds, and we all have a different education and experiences. So it's natural that we may have a different understanding and perspective toward the same thing and thus give different evaluations. To reach an agreement, we should learn to stand in the other person's shoes, seeking common ground while setting aside differences. The goal of our conversation is to solve the problem, not to win a debate.

In response to the second assumption, in which the other person is ill-intentioned, we should realize that conflicts are irrelevant to intentions, and we should not make assumptions about the other person's intentions. During a conflict, intentions often become the focus of the argument, and assumptions made on this matter heavily affect the judgments we make. This happens when someone offends us. We might believe they are picking on us, or is simply ignoring our feelings. Because of this assumption, we strike



back at full force. In contrast, if we are willing to learn and listen to what the other person has to say, we are more likely to accept or understand it. With different attitudes, we can give contrasting responses to the same situation. Therefore, we should not assume the other person's intentions as we are talking. Rather, we should try to understand each other and reflect on whether we did something wrong.

Finally, the way to solve the third assumption, which holds that it is the other person who should take responsibility, is to quit blaming. In our lives, things usually go wrong due to more than one factor. When something is screwed up, our reaction is often to blame others and claim our own innocence. However, this is of no help in conflict resolution. Moreover, playing the blame game brings along many other negative side effects, such as resentment, conflict, and passivity. Blame is like pressing a spring, which pushes back with resistance. The right thing to do is to talk about ways to contribute, rather than the topic of blame. A blame frame is about judgment; it requires someone to shoulder all the responsibility, and it's about looking backward. On the contrary, a contribution frame asks for understanding and actively sharing the responsibility; it's about looking forward. With the other person, we can examine why



something went wrong. We can discuss how to make up for it and take relevant measures to prevent the same mistake from happening again in the future.

OK, now we've finished talking about the "what happened" conversation and the corresponding strategies to change it. Let's move on to the second component of a difficult conversation, the Feelings Conversation. In a Feelings Conversation, we let our feelings take over, which turn a conversation into a confrontation.

It's quite challenging to manage our feelings. Many conversations are difficult, not due to their contents, but due to our failure to control our emotions. Think about your past experiences. Didn't you have complex and turbulent feelings in every difficult conversation that ever occurred? When someone treats us unfairly, or when someone disrespects us, we feel hurt, angry, and also disappointed. Our negative emotions are like bulls in a ring, uncontrolled by reason and driving us so crazy that we want to tear the other person to pieces.

Take this example; A car crashes into the one in front of it and the driver of the car that rear-ended knows it's their fault.



But the driver of the car in front begins to shout obscenities the moment they get out of their own car. From then on, the driver of the car behind explodes into a fit of anger. With no control over their emotions, they both curse at each other and get into a physical fight. Finally, several policemen have to come and intervene due to what started out as just a minor accident.

Why would something like that happen? The authors of another book on the same subject, ‘Crucial Conversations: Tools for taking when Stakes are High’, tell us that this process is programmed in our physiology. As we become angry or scared, a large amount of adrenaline is released into our blood. When our brain receives this signal, it dispatches blood from organs to limbs in order to prepare for a fight-or-flight response. When your limbs are in a state of high tension due to congestion, your brain, however, goes blank due to the lack of blood supply, and thus you become controlled by your emotions. You can find the book ‘Crucial Conversations’ in Bookey, too.

So how can we manage our feelings? The book offers some advice.

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To handle this, first, know your feelings. For example, what would make you lose your temper? What irritates you? What frightens you? What makes you want to escape? As we grow up, each of us develops a characteristic “emotional footprint.” Make a list of your feelings, which can raise your awareness over what you emotions you experience and why.

The book provides a good example. Brad often quarreled with his mother while he was job hunting. His mother frequently called and urged him to send resumes, to go to interviews, and to search for job listings online. However, Brad wasn’t enthusiastic about it. He complained to a friend about his aversion to his mother’s pressure. His friend suggested that he consider the emotions that he was feeling besides anger.

When he made a list of his feelings about job hunting, Brad was surprised to find that he was feeling hopeless, confused, and afraid. Putting off the search was his way of putting off some of this anxiety. His feelings about his mother were rather more complicated. On the one hand, he found her constant prodding to be a great annoyance. On the other hand, he also experienced it as a form of love and concern. Knowing about how he was feeling helped Brad know



himself better and stop responding to the situation with anger.

Another thing we can do to manage our feelings is to alter our way of thinking. Though our feelings are affected by external influences, they can change with a change in our perception. Imagine that while scuba diving, you see a shark swimming toward you. You become terrified. But then you remember that you've once seen this type of shark in a documentary, and can identify it as a Reef Shark, which doesn't prey on humans. From here on, your fear vanishes immediately and you even have the curiosity to observe the shark for a little while. This case shows that our feelings can change with our thoughts.

A third way to manage our feelings is to express them appropriately. Everyone's feelings deserve to be fully expressed and listened to. Make sure that the other person understands your feelings. Expressing your feelings fully and clearly may not eliminate the conflict, but it helps ease the anxiety that may lead to a quarrel. Both sides of the conversation can have the chance to know each other better and focus on solving the problem.



Let's turn these solutions back to Brad's job hunting case. He could instead say to his mother, "Mom, you keep urging me to find a job, and that makes me feel uneasy. I know you care about me, but it makes me feel ashamed, as if I'm letting you down. I'm sure that things will turn out better in the future, but please, allow me time to handle it, OK?" Once his feelings are fully expressed, it no longer becomes a battle with anger. Rather, the discussion with his mother can achieve more depth and become more effective.

That concludes the part about the second component of a difficult conversation and the strategies to change it. Next, let's move on to the third reason for difficult conversations, the Identity Conversation. In an Identity Conversation, we tend to protect our self-esteem blindly, which puts the conversation into a deadlock.

When a difficult conversation threatens our self-identity, it's hard to proceed. Furthermore, the conversation might even end abruptly. Everyone has a self-identity. There are three particularly common identity issues: Am I competent? Am I a good person? Am I worthy of love? We establish our self-worth through these perceptions. When others deny our self-identity, our self-esteem gets crushed. Why do people



argue? Why do people shirk responsibility? This is due to our self-esteem and how we value ourselves. No one wants to be criticized. Everyone wishes to be the one who is competent, loving, confident, and successful. Such is human nature.

If a conversation questions our self-identity, we lose our inner balance and become irrational. Imagine someone says to you, "Who do you think you are? Your marriage failed. How dare you give me a lesson?" Or, "Your work performance is so bad; you think you can compete for the promotion?" Hearing this, we feel that our image is damaged and our self-esteem offended, and thus the conversation inevitably slips into a crisis. Either your brain goes blank, having no idea what to do except run away, or you become furious and fight back with force, turning the conversation into a confrontation.

What should we do instead? Again, the book offers us three strategies.

First of all, we should ground our identity. Many of us are always living by others' criteria. They yearn for others' praise and recognition. Some of them lose themselves as they try to please others. Some of them have severe anxiety when



their self-worth gets questioned. But in fact, our self-worth has nothing to do with other people's opinions. We don't have to live under the shadow of someone else's evaluation. We don't need others to judge our achievements or failures. What we should do is retain our own rationality and ground our identities.

Secondly, we need to examine ourselves objectively. This requires us to admit to our own shortcomings. Everyone makes mistakes. When you make a mistake, don't give meaningless excuses. Just admit it and accept the criticism responsibly. For instance, if something unpleasant happens, we should immediately reflect on what we haven't done properly and tell the other person, "I apologize for my mistakes during the preparation. I see they have brought trouble to our cooperation. Again, I apologize." In a difficult conversation, the more easily we can take responsibility and admit our mistakes, the more balanced we can feel, and the higher the chance is for the conversation to undergo a breakthrough.

Thirdly, we should give up trying to control others' reactions, as the more control we impose, the more resistant the other person will become. Imagine you have a son, and



you want him to receive an A in every course he takes. So you ask him to study a lot every day, unknowingly giving him a burdening amount of stress. With this pressure, your child may believe that you only care about his grades, not his feelings, and may rebel against you. We can't change anyone but ourselves. For others, we can only influence them at best. Thus you should learn to let go.

To summarize, in an Identity Conversation, we can dodge the bullet by improving our self-perception. Furthermore, we should learn to incorporate new information into our self-perception and change our old extreme way of thinking.

That concludes the first part of this Bookey. We now know that a difficult conversation is essentially 3 conversations. First, in the “What Happened?” conversation, we make assumptions that lead to meaningless and endless disputes. Second, in the Feelings conversation, we let our feelings take over, which turns conversations into confrontations. And third, in the Identity conversation, we blindly protect our self-esteem, making the conversation end in deadlock. The authors offer solutions to each of these situations. They advise us to stop arguing about who is right, make no assumptions about the other person’s intentions, quit



blaming, manage our feelings, and adjust our perception of ourselves. By doing these things, we can make our conversations more effective.

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Chapter 3 : The right steps to take in a difficult conversation

Now that we know what make up a difficult conversation and the right directions and attitudes we should take in response to them, we can now move on to tackle difficult conversations. To be specific, what should we do during difficult conversations? How should we get started? What should we pay attention to during the conversation? And how should we end it? The authors advise us to follow the following practical steps. First, clarify the purpose of the conversation. Second, start with a neutral opening. Third, listen carefully to what the other person has to say and express your own thoughts clearly. And fourth, reframe the conversation when it reaches a dead end.

First, let's look at how to clarify the purpose of the conversation. Only with a clear purpose can a conversation stay on track.

Do we think about the purpose of the conversation every time we start one? Sometimes a conversation happens without notice. We may not have figured out what to say



before it starts, or the conversation may end before we actually understand what we've been talking about.

Sometimes, we start a conversation with a purpose but then lose track of it as soon as we open our mouths. Take this case as an example; Because a child plays so many video games that his grades begin to drop, his mom complains to her husband, "You go out every day. Have you ever given a thought to your kid's studies?" What she actually means is for her husband to spend more time with their child and help him with his schoolwork. However, the husband may think she is blaming him for not caring about his family.

The right thing to do is to ask yourself before starting a conversation 'what do I need?', "What is my goal?" In the previous example, the wife could say, "I have to spend a lot of time doing housework, and I am too exhausted to continuously keep our son company. Can you go out less and stay with him more? His teacher told me that kids get

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Chapter 4 : Summary & Review

Now that we've talked about the main points of the book 'Difficult Conversations', let's take a moment to summarize it.

In the first part, we talked about how each difficult conversation is essentially three conversations, followed with the corresponding strategies to change them. The first one is the "What happened?" conversation. In this realm, we can become stuck by the three assumptions we make. We assume that the other person is wrong, is ill-intentioned, and should take responsibility. As a result, our conversation slips into a continuous loop of arguments about who's right and who's wrong. The second one is the Feelings conversation. When we are treated unfairly, we tend to lose our minds and let our feelings control us. The third one is the Identity conversation. When our self-identity is threatened, we fight back in self-defense which inevitably leads the conversation to a disaster. The authors offer several targeted methods to handle these conversations, including stopping the right-or-wrong arguments, making no assumptions about others' intentions, stopping blaming, managing our emotions, and adjusting our self-identity. All these contribute to a more productive



conversation.

In Part Two, we talked about the right steps to take in difficult conversations.

Step one is setting up a clear goal for the conversation to keep it on the right course. Step two is taking a neutral stance in the conversation by mediating the issue as a third-party observer. Step three is establishing two-way communication, meaning to listen carefully and express yourself clearly. The last step is reframing the conversation when it reaches a deadlock and bring it back on track until the problem gets solved.

Learning about difficult conversations is not only knowing about how to solve problems. What we really need is to learn to break out of our deep-rooted ways of thinking and reflect effectively. Once you realize that you can't change others, you learn to give up on controlling them and reflect on yourself. We should try to change our own perspectives, see the issue from different angles, and invite others to join in on our efforts. Only by doing so can conversational deadlocks be broken and problems be solved.

